

Coding Qualitative Data

From raw text to structured meaning — the mechanics beneath analysis

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Coding is the process of labelling segments of qualitative data with tags that capture their meaning, so that patterns can be identified and retrieved systematically. It is the engine beneath thematic analysis, grounded theory and framework analysis. Codes may be descriptive (what is there), in-vivo (the participant's own words) or analytic (a concept you bring). Coding turns unstructured transcripts into an auditable, searchable dataset (Saldaña, 2021).

CODING CYCLES

First-cycle coding assigns initial labels close to the data (descriptive, in-vivo, process codes). Second-cycle coding groups and refines these into categories and themes (pattern coding, focused coding). Coding is iterative — you revise codes as understanding deepens.

INDUCTIVE vs DEDUCTIVE CODES

Inductive (open) codes are generated from the data itself. Deductive (a priori) codes come from an existing framework or theory applied to the data. Many studies blend both. Declare which you used, and keep a codebook defining each code.

The codebook is your audit trail. A codebook lists each code, its definition, an example extract, and rules for when it applies and does not. It makes your analysis transparent, supports consistency across coding sessions, and is exactly what an examiner looks for when testing whether findings are grounded in data.

Code type	Source	Example
Descriptive	The data's content	'onboarding delay'
In-vivo	Participant's words	'thrown in the deep end'
Process	Action / gerund	'negotiating access'
A priori	Existing framework	'perceived usefulness' (TAM)

KEEP A CODEBOOK

Define every code with an example and boundary rules. It is the single most useful rigour artefact for qualitative work.

TOOLS HELP

NVivo, ATLAS.ti, Dedoose or even a well-structured spreadsheet organise coding — but the analytic thinking is still yours.

CHECK CONSISTENCY

If coding over time or with others, re-check earlier transcripts against your evolving codes to keep application consistent.

Common pitfalls. (1) Coding with no codebook. (2) Codes so broad they capture everything and distinguish nothing. (3) Never revisiting early transcripts after codes evolve. (4) Presenting codes as findings without lifting them into themes and interpretation.

REFERENCES

Saldaña, J. (2021) *The Coding Manual for Qualitative Researchers*. 4th edn. London: SAGE. · Miles, M.B., Huberman, A.M. and Saldaña, J. (2020) *Qualitative Data Analysis*. 4th edn. Thousand Oaks: SAGE.